

Heart Valve Disease Risks and Diagnosis

Heart Valve Disease Resources

- [What is Heart Valve Disease? \(PDF\)](#)
- [Understanding Heart Valve Disease \(PDF\)](#)
- [Symptom Tracker \(PDF\)](#)
- [HVD Discussion Guide \(PDF\)](#)
- [After HVD Diagnosis Discussion Guide \(PDF\)](#)

Who's at risk for heart valve disease?

Heart valve disease is more common among older people. As we age, our heart valves can become lined with calcium deposits that cause the valve flaps to thicken and become stiffer. Others with a greater risk for heart valve disease include:

- People who have had [rheumatic fever](#) or [infective endocarditis](#)
- Those with heart problems such as [heart attack](#), [heart failure](#) or [congenital heart disease](#)
- Childhood cancer survivors who had radiation therapy on the heart or surrounding tissues

You should get regular checkups and watch out for symptoms that are new or getting worse if you have been diagnosed with:

- A [heart murmur](#)
- A defect such as a [bicuspid aortic valve](#)
- [Mitral valve prolapse](#)
- A mild form of [valve disease](#)

Valve disease and health risks

Many people with a mild valve problem can live long and healthy lives and never notice any [symptoms](#). However, if left untreated, advanced valve disease can cause heart failure, stroke, blood clots or, in very severe cases, sudden cardiac death.

How is heart valve disease diagnosed?

Healthcare professionals may discover signs of heart valve disease during a physical exam. When they listen to the heart with a stethoscope, they may hear an abnormal heart sound, or murmur, like a whooshing or clicking.

When healthcare professionals suspect heart valve disease, they offer [tests](#) to diagnose the condition. These can include:

- Echocardiogram
- Imaging tests, such as X-ray, CT scan or cardiac MRI
- Exercise stress test
- Electrocardiogram

Once heart valve disease is diagnosed, the healthcare professional will talk with the patient about regular monitoring and [treatment options](#).

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The Importance of Tracking Heart Valve Disease Symptoms

Video: Dr. Robert Bonow on Heart Valve Disease

- Heart Valves and Circulation
- Heart Valve Problems and Causes
- Risks and Diagnosis
 - Symptoms of Heart Valve Disease
 - Managing Aortic Stenosis Symptoms
- Getting an Accurate Diagnosis
- Treatment Options
- Recovery and Healthy Living Goals
- Personal Stories
- Heart Valve Disease Resources



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[Testing for Heart Valve Problems](#)

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